

School Capability & Workload Diagnostic Matrix

The questions should help determine:

- How curriculum, units and assessment are currently developed
- Who is responsible for each stage of the process
- How much staff time each process requires
- Whether teachers are recreating resources that already exist
- Whether expectations are clear and consistent
- Whether processes differ unnecessarily between departments or year levels
- What work is being completed outside ordinary working hours
- What administrative work could be simplified, standardised or automated
- Whether staff have the resources and confidence to deliver the required units
- Whether leadership can see where workload and delivery problems are occurring

The key shift in the matrix

Rather than asking only:

“Does the school have a curriculum plan?”

The diagnostic should ask:

“How is the curriculum plan created, who contributes to it, how long does it take, how consistently is it used, and what additional work must teachers complete before they can teach from it?”

That gives you a much more useful picture.

A school may technically have a curriculum plan, but teachers might still be:

- Writing units from scratch
- Searching for suitable resources
- Reformatting documents into different templates
- Creating individual rubrics
- Interpreting achievement standards without sufficient guidance
- Repeating planning already completed elsewhere
- Completing reporting and moderation work after hours
- Managing multiple platforms containing conflicting information

Those are the areas where your service can create measurable value.

Proposed Diagnostic structure

1. School direction and expectations

Diagnostic question	What it reveals	Potential improvement
What are the school's current teaching and learning priorities?	Whether staff work is aligned to leadership priorities	Align planning and resources to strategic priorities
How are curriculum expectations communicated to staff?	Whether teachers receive clear and consistent direction	Create a consistent communication and implementation process
Are expectations consistent across year levels and departments?	Whether staff are working under different interpretations	Develop whole school expectations and guidance
Who approves curriculum, units and assessment?	Whether decision making responsibilities are clear	Establish a clear approval pathway
How frequently do curriculum expectations change?	Whether repeated changes are causing unnecessary rework	Introduce planned review and change management cycles

2. Curriculum planning process

Diagnostic question	What it reveals	Potential improvement
Who develops the whole school curriculum plan?	Responsibility and workload allocation	Clarify ownership and distribute work appropriately
How are Australian Curriculum requirements translated into school plans?	Staff curriculum knowledge and interpretation burden	Develop curriculum maps and implementation guidance
Are units mapped across subjects and year levels?	Gaps, duplication and sequencing issues	Create a whole school curriculum map
How often are curriculum plans reviewed?	Whether review is systematic or reactive	Establish an achievable review cycle
How much time do staff spend interpreting curriculum documentation?	Hidden curriculum planning workload	Provide simplified curriculum guidance and mapped resources
Are teachers planning independently or collaboratively?	Duplication and consistency risks	Create collaborative planning structures and shared resources

3. Unit Development & Delivery Readiness

This section is particularly important because it establishes whether teachers are being given materials they can genuinely deliver.

Diagnostic question	What it reveals	Potential improvement
What materials does a teacher receive before beginning a unit?	Whether units are genuinely classroom ready	Establish a minimum unit resource standard
Are learning intentions, success criteria and achievement standards clearly connected?	Whether teachers must make additional interpretations	Develop aligned unit and lesson documentation
Are units complete, partially developed or merely outlined?	The amount of preparation still required	Produce complete or enhanced units
Are lesson sequences included?	Whether teachers must build the delivery sequence themselves	Develop sequenced learning experiences
Are suitable teaching resources identified and accessible?	Time spent searching for resources	Build curated resource collections
Are adjustments and differentiation considerations included?	Additional planning required for diverse learners	Add differentiation and adjustment guidance
Can a new or relief teacher deliver the unit from the available documentation?	Clarity, usability and organisational resilience	Improve unit completeness and accessibility
How much additional preparation is required before each lesson?	Actual delivery workload	Reduce lesson preparation through reusable resources
Are units reviewed after delivery?	Whether problems are captured and corrected	Introduce a practical post unit review process

4. Assessment Development

Diagnostic question	What it reveals	Potential improvement
Who creates assessment tasks?	Workload distribution	Centralise or coordinate task development
Are assessment tasks reused, adapted or rewritten each year?	Repeated effort and resource loss	Build an approved assessment library
How are tasks aligned to curriculum standards?	Curriculum capability and compliance risk	Create an assessment alignment process
Are task specific standards or rubrics provided?	Whether teachers must create their own marking tools	Develop task specific rubrics
How long does it take to develop an assessment task?	Actual development burden	Standardise templates and processes
How are assessments reviewed before use?	Quality assurance efficiency	Introduce an assessment review checklist

Diagnostic question	What it reveals	Potential improvement
Are expectations clear to students and families?	Communication and transparency	Improve task sheets and assessment guidance

5. Marking, Moderation & Reporting

Diagnostic question	What it reveals	Potential improvement
How much time do teachers spend marking each assessment cycle?	Major workload pressure points	Review assessment design and marking efficiency
Are common rubrics and annotations used?	Consistency and duplicated work	Develop standard rubrics and annotated examples
How is moderation conducted?	Whether moderation is effective or unnecessarily burdensome	Design a streamlined moderation process
When does moderation occur?	Whether it happens during paid working time	Build moderation into the operating calendar
How are report comments prepared?	Repeated administrative workload	Develop comment structures and guidance
Are teachers entering the same information into multiple systems?	Administrative duplication	Simplify data entry processes
Which reporting activities are completed outside working hours?	Unsustainable practices	Redesign schedules and reporting workflows

6. Meetings and collaboration

Diagnostic question	What it reveals	Potential improvement
How many curriculum and planning meetings are held each term?	Time investment	Review meeting frequency and purpose
Does each meeting have a clear decision or deliverable?	Meeting effectiveness	Introduce structured agendas and outcomes
Are staff required to attend meetings that do not directly concern their work?	Unnecessary time use	Refine participation requirements
Are decisions recorded and accessible?	Repeated conversations and confusion	Establish a central decision record
Is collaboration producing shared resources?	Whether meetings reduce or add to workload	Tie collaboration to tangible outputs
Are teachers given protected planning time?	Whether collaboration occurs after hours	Establish protected planning arrangements

7. Systems, Platforms & Resource Management

Diagnostic question	What it reveals	Potential improvement
Where are curriculum documents stored?	Accessibility and version control issues	Create a logical central resource structure
How many platforms must teachers use?	Digital complexity	Consolidate or clarify system purposes
Can staff easily find the current version of a document?	Time lost searching and checking	Improve file naming and version control
Are resources duplicated across drives or platforms?	Inefficient storage and maintenance	Establish a single source of truth
How are new staff introduced to systems and resources?	Onboarding effectiveness	Develop a structured onboarding package
Which administrative tasks are completed manually?	Automation opportunities	Simplify or automate appropriate processes
Are staff confident using existing technology?	Capability gaps	Provide targeted professional learning

8. Workload & Working Hours

This section should be handled constructively and without making staff feel scrutinised.

Diagnostic question	What it reveals	Potential improvement
Which tasks most frequently require work outside normal hours?	Primary workload pressures	Prioritise high impact process improvements
At which points of the term is workload least manageable?	Workload peaks	Redesign the annual operating calendar
Which tasks take longer than staff believe they should?	Inefficient processes	Investigate and simplify the process
What work is regularly taken home?	Hidden organisational workload	Develop in school completion strategies
What tasks are duplicated by multiple staff members?	Wasted capacity	Introduce shared ownership and reusable resources
What could the school provide that would save teachers the most time?	Staff defined priorities	Create targeted practical deliverables
What prevents teachers from completing work during allocated time?	Structural barriers	Address scheduling, meetings, systems or resource availability
Which processes generate the most frustration?	Wellbeing and retention risks	Prioritise quick operational improvements

The objective is not simply to ask teachers how many hours they work. It is to identify **why the work cannot be completed within available time.**

9. Staff capability and confidence

Diagnostic question	What it reveals	Potential improvement
Which curriculum processes do staff find most difficult?	Capability development priorities	Provide targeted curriculum support
Are staff confident interpreting achievement standards?	Assessment capability	Develop standards and rubric training
Are teachers confident adapting existing units?	Unit delivery flexibility	Provide unit adaptation guidance
Are early career teachers receiving sufficient support?	Retention and onboarding risks	Develop an early career support structure
Do middle leaders have sufficient time and capability to support their teams?	Leadership workload and implementation capacity	Strengthen middle leadership processes
Is professional learning connected to immediate classroom needs?	Practical value of staff development	Design applied professional learning
Are staff shown how new processes will save time?	Implementation acceptance	Build staff benefit into change communication

10. AI & Digital Workload Reduction

Diagnostic question	What it reveals	Potential improvement
How are staff currently using generative AI?	Existing practice and risk	Establish responsible use guidance
Which repetitive tasks may be appropriately supported by AI?	Potential time savings	Develop approved workflows and examples
Does the school have clear AI expectations?	Governance and consistency	Develop AI guidelines or policy
Are staff confident checking AI generated content?	Quality and accuracy risk	Provide verification and judgement tools
Can AI support planning without replacing teacher judgement?	Appropriate use opportunities	Develop teacher controlled AI processes
Are privacy and security requirements understood?	Information management risk	Establish clear privacy guardrails
Could existing digital systems reduce repeated administration?	Unused system capability	Improve platform configuration and training

Process Mapping Questions

For each major school process, the interviewer should work through the same sequence:

1. **What is the process?**
2. **Why is it required?**
3. **Who is involved?**
4. **Who owns the final outcome?**
5. **When does it occur?**
6. **How long does it take?**
7. **What systems and documents are used?**
8. **What happens before and after this step?**
9. **Where are delays or frustrations occurring?**
10. **What work must be completed outside allocated time?**
11. **What is duplicated or repeated?**
12. **What would make the process easier?**
13. **What could be removed without reducing educational quality?**
14. **What could be standardised, shared or automated?**
15. **How would the school know the process had improved?**

This same sequence can be applied to:

- Unit planning
- Assessment creation
- Resource preparation
- Moderation
- Reporting
- Parent communication
- Curriculum reviews
- Staff meetings
- Professional learning
- New teacher onboarding
- Data collection and analysis

Turning Findings Into a Clear Path

Each issue identified should result in a structured action record.

Field	Purpose
Current process	How the school presently completes the work
Intended outcome	What the process is supposed to achieve
Staff involved	Who performs or approves the work
Estimated staff time	Time currently being consumed
Pain point	What makes the work difficult or inefficient

Field	Purpose
Educational risk	Potential impact on curriculum or students
Workload risk	Potential impact on staff hours and wellbeing
Root cause	Why the problem is occurring
Recommended action	What should change
Deliverable	The tangible item or service to be provided
Owner	Person responsible for implementation
Target date	Achievable completion points
Success measure	Evidence that the change has worked
Review date	When the outcome will be evaluated

Example outcome

Finding: Teachers are individually creating Year 5 English units from curriculum documents and locating their own resources.

Impact:

- Significant duplicated planning time
- Inconsistent unit quality
- Different interpretations of curriculum requirements
- Increased after hours work
- Difficulty supporting new teachers

Objective:

By the beginning of the next semester, the school will provide all Year 5 English teachers with an agreed, curriculum aligned unit package that can be delivered without extensive additional planning.

Deliverables:

- Eight week unit plan
- Curriculum and achievement standard mapping
- Sequenced learning experiences
- Assessment task
- Task specific rubric
- Recommended teaching resources
- Differentiation guidance
- Teacher notes
- Post unit evaluation template

Success measures:

- Teachers can commence delivery without recreating the unit
- Planning preparation time is reduced

- All classes address the agreed curriculum requirements
- Staff report improved confidence and clarity
- The unit can be reused and improved in subsequent years

Core principle

The primary question throughout the engagement should be:

Does this process help teachers deliver better learning, or does it create additional work without sufficient educational benefit?

That keeps the review focused on meaningful improvement rather than removing processes simply to save time. The intended result is a school where teachers have clear expectations, accessible resources, workable systems and enough professional capacity to deliver their teaching without routinely relying on unpaid additional hours.